

TODAY — DO NOT MISS

ILT Academy · SDR interview

Wed Sep 2, 2026 · 2:45 PM CDT · Google Meet: meet.google.com/zxz-gtdb-gbyInterviewer: **Kenzie Kitzman** · kenzie@iltacademy.io

OPENING LINE (use their words)

“You’re a modern business school for serious entrepreneurs — trade-school style, not theory. Two motions: paid seats at \$3k/\$6k, and partners who fund seats so underestimated builders in underserved communities can train for free. Kenzie, I want to understand whether this SDR seat is filling cohorts, filling partner pipelines, or both — and then show you I can run that motion.”

1. WHAT ILT ACADEMY IS

Their line: “A Modern Business School for Serious Entrepreneurs.” Tagline: *Think Big. Start Small. Act Faster.* Hashtag: #ilikethat (ILT = “I like that” — confirmed in a 2025 MnDOT-region annual report).

- **Product:** Live virtual entrepreneur training. Lean startup, design thinking, customer discovery, AI woven into every session. “Not a course. It’s coaching.” No pre-recorded content.
- **Core SKUs:** 100 Series Bootcamp — 11 weeks, 1 session/week, 6:00–10:00 PM CST, **\$3,000/builder** (team \$2,550 with code TeamQ226). 300 Series — advanced, 100 Series required first, **\$6,000/builder** (team \$5,100). Also listed: Sprints, Builder Lab, Webinars (pricing unknown).
- **Capstones:** 100 Series → Founder Showcase. 300 Series → Demo Day + Rapid Prototype Weekend + 4 mentor sessions.
- **Business model (two revenue paths, both on-site):** (A) Direct tuition. (B) Partners “fund the seats. We deliver the training.” Scholarships = same program, partner-paid.
- **HQ:** St. Cloud, MN. Founded 2020 by Nick Tietz (About page). Copyright 2026 ILT Studios. Programs 100% live virtual; “open to the world.”
- **Proof they publish:** 1,200+ founders trained · \$27M+ raised by alumni · 55 cohorts · 850+ companies launched · \$572K federal SSBCI contract (partners page).
- **Legal/size:** Small team (About lists 6 people by name). LinkedIn company page shows 1–10 employees (~9). Remote possible — Kenzie is listed as Colorado Springs on LinkedIn (third-party scrape; confirm).
- **Unknown:** SDR job posting not found on public web. Comp, quota, equity, W-2 vs 1099, full-time vs contract — all unknown.

2. WHO THE BUYER IS (TWO ICPs)

Do not mash these together in the interview. Ask which motion this seat owns.

ICP A — THE BUILDER (admissions)

Site language: “two kinds of builders.” High tech / low tech / no tech / nonprofits. Individuals + teams.

- **Idea stage:** hasn’t launched; needs to test before wasting time/money.
- **In business:** customers exist but “something isn’t clicking” — stalled growth, inconsistent revenue.
- **300 Series:** validated concept or active business ready to scale / get investor-ready.
- **Scholarship ICP:** idea/company in NE MN, East Central MN, 6 Tribal Nations, or Central MN (Benton/Sherburne/Stearns).

- **Titles:** Founder, Co-Founder, CEO — not corporate buyers.

ICP B — THE FUNDER (partnerships)

Site: EDOs, state agencies, tribal orgs, regional funders. “Sponsoring a cohort is the most direct investment you can make in the builders in your region.”

- **Named partners:** Northspan / DAWN; Greater St. Cloud Development Corp; ND Dept of Commerce (SSBCI); Greater Fargo Moorhead EDC; Itasca EDC / Innovate 218; Finnovation Lab (CDFI); MnDOT (homepage logo + shared-mobility incubator).
- **Partner types listed:** EDOs · state workforce/commerce/DEED · federal (SSBCI, MBDA, SBA) · tribal ED · CDFIs · chambers · WIOA boards · corporate foundations.
- **Titles on site:** Elissa Hansen, President & CEO, Northspan · Shayden Akason, Deputy Director, ED Finance, ND Commerce · John Machacek, Greater Fargo Moorhead EDC.
- **What they buy:** full/partial seats in 100, 300, Builder Labs, or Sprints. Co-branded delivery + outcome reports for grants/boards/legislators.

3. PAINS THEY CLAIM TO SOLVE

Builders (their words):

- Know how to build a product, not a business (Ryan Johnston / Waypoint).
- Stuck at idea; need idea → execution (Ramsey Shaffer).
- Don't fit the “tech unicorn entrepreneur” stereotype; diversity talk vs access (Clare Richards).
- No discovery funnel / no PMF (Lucas Cunha, Otrafy).
- Indecisive business, multiple branches, no vision (Annie Qaiser).
- Need biz model, messaging, investor pitch to raise (Lisa Kosciuk / Verdethos).
- Rural / tribal / Greater MN builders locked out of coastal-style training. “Talent is evenly distributed. Opportunity is not.”
- AI era: “knowing how to leverage AI isn't optional. It's the edge.”

Partners (their words):

- “The training infrastructure your region has been missing.”
- Entrepreneurs with bold ideas who “just need some support to get their ideas off the ground” (Hansen / Northspan).
- State needs “more at-bats” so ideas don't sit on the back burner (Akason / ND).
- Need a feeder into Innovate ND, gBETA, other programs (Machacek).
- Rural/remote communities that in-person programs miss; 7 Native Nations.
- Need reportable metrics: businesses launched, capital raised, jobs created — formatted for grants, legislative reports, boards.
- Federal compliance/reporting (they sell SSBCI track record).

4. HOW AN SDR WOULD ACTUALLY SELL IT

INFERENCE — no public SDR job description found. Kenzie's July 2026 promotion is to **Senior Business Development and Admissions Executive** (LinkedIn company post). Site About still says Operations & Admissions Lead (stale). This interview is most likely for capacity under her new dual title. Confirm on the call.

Motion A — Admissions (fill the cohort)

- **Who you call:** applicants, webinar/event attendees, alumni referrals, regional scholarship applicants, teams (2+ builders). Contact on site: Kenzie / admissions@iltacademy.io / 320-406-1490.
- **What you book:** written application + video interview (scholarship path is 3-step and competitive). Or checkout for \$3k/\$6k. Team pricing = email Kenzie.
- **Now enrolling:** Summer 2026 100 Series — Tue Jun 2–Aug 13 or Thu Jun 4–Aug 13. 300 Series Mon Jun 1–Aug 11. Showcase Aug 13. Demo Day Aug 12.
- **Likely objections:** “\$3k isn’t worth it” (they have an FAQ with that exact header) · time (4-hr live night class) · “I’ll wait / I’m not ready” · “I already have a business” · “I can YouTube lean startup” · scholarship waitlist / outside county · 300 Series requires 100 first.

Motion B — Partnerships (sell seats in bulk)

- **Who you call:** EDO presidents, economic-development finance, commerce/DEED program officers, tribal ED, CDFI program leads, chamber entrepreneurship directors, WIOA boards, corporate foundation program officers. Inbound: partner@iltacademy.io / hello@iltacademy.io.
- **What you book:** “Talk to our team” / partnership conversation with Kenzie (she is now the named BD person). Not a demo of software — a delivery-partner conversation: who they serve, what outcomes their funders need, how ILT delivers.
- **Offer:** You fund seats. We recruit, curriculum, facilitate, coach, track outcomes. Co-brand. Same competitive application — no separate form.
- **Proof pack:** 1,200+ trained, \$27M raised, 55 cohorts, \$572K SSBCI, Northspan 139 entrepreneurs / 16 cohorts / 10 counties / 7 Native Nations (partners page — note About says 6 Native Nations; don’t mix the numbers).
- **Likely objections:** already have SBDC / LaunchMN / gBETA / Co.Starters · budget cycle / grant timing · “is this just another webinar?” · virtual = low completion (counter: live 4-hr sessions, accountability, showcase) · equity concerns (they take **no equity**) · “will our rural people actually apply?” · federal reporting burden (they claim they handle it) · overlap with MnDOT-only mobility program vs general entrepreneurship.

Sales language to steal

- Entrepreneurship is a skilled trade — like welding or plumbing.
- The framework exists. Anyone serious enough can learn it.
- You fund the seats. We deliver the training.
- This is not a course. It’s coaching.
- No equity taken. No selection bias toward fundable startups.
- Serious builders. Underestimated entrepreneurs. Underserved communities.

5. COMPETITORS

FACT: ILT does not name competitors on its site. They differentiate vs “accelerators” (300 Series FAQ: “How is this different from an accelerator?”) and vs theory-heavy school. They take no equity. They sell as feeder *into* gBETA / Innovate ND (Machacek quote).

INFERENCE — adjacent landscape, not ILT’s list: gener8tor / gBETA (Kenzie’s LinkedIn history includes Associate at gener8tor) · BETA.MN · LaunchMN / DEED technical assistance · SBDC · Co.Starters / local ignite programs · university entrepreneurship centers · Founder Institute / online cohort products · SCORE. For partners, the real alternative is “we run it in-house” or “we already fund X.” Do not bash; ask how they position vs gBETA/SBDC.

6. LIKELY QUESTIONS + SHARP ANSWERS

Ground answers in *their* language. Don't oversell Silicon Valley SDR theater to a 9-person St. Cloud shop.

Q: Why ILT / why this role?

A: Mission is concrete: underestimated entrepreneurs, underserved communities, skilled-trade training. Dual motion (tuition + sponsored seats) is a real GTM, not a vague "edtech." Kenzie just stepped into BD+Admissions — this is a scale hire, not a tourist SDR seat. I want to be the person who keeps cohorts and partner pipelines full so she isn't doing ops + sales alone.

Q: What do we sell?

A: Two products, one delivery: 11-week live virtual coaching. 100 Series \$3k foundation (idea or stuck-in-business). 300 Series \$6k, 100 required, investor-ready. Partners buy seats so their region's builders attend the same program. Not a LMS. Not an accelerator that takes equity.

Q: Who is the customer?

A: Ask back: "Which motion is this seat on?" Then: Builders = founders. Partners = EDO/state/tribal/CDFI buyers measured on businesses launched, capital, jobs — the metrics on your partners page.

Q: Walk me through how you'd prospect a partner.

A: Start with who they already trust: Northspan, GSCDC, ND Commerce, Fargo EDC, Itasca/Innovate 218, Finnovation, MnDOT. Map lookalikes: other regional EDOs, tribal ED, WIOA boards, CDFIs, SSBCI administrators in nearby states. Trigger: new grant, DAWN-style program, rural entrepreneurship mandate. Outreach: region + outcome language, not 'book a demo.' Ask who they serve, what their funders need to see, whether they have training infrastructure or a gap. Book Kenzie.

Q: How would you fill a Summer cohort?

A: Know the dates. 100 Series Tue/Thu nights Jun–Aug 13. Scholarship apps rolling; awardees ~2 weeks before start. Funnel: events (Pitch Night, Startup Connect, webinars) → application → video → decision. Paid path is checkout. I'd ask: what's conversion written→video→enroll, and where do no-shows die? Then work that leak.

Q: Why would someone pay \$3,000?

A: They already wrote the FAQ. Counter: live, not pre-recorded; applied to YOUR idea; EIR + office hours + showcase; alumni \$27M / YC / Techstars proof. Scholarship exists if you're in-region. If money is the block, the honest move is the partner-funded seat, not a discount war.

Q: How is this different from an accelerator / gBETA / SBDC?

A: You take no equity. You're training infrastructure, not a 3-month equity program. Partners say you feed Innovate ND and gBETA. SBDC is counseling; you're a structured 11-week cohort with deliverables (Lean Canvas, discovery plan, proforma, pitch). Don't trash them — you're the on-ramp.

Q: Tell me about a time you booked meetings / handled no.

A: Use a real Evan story. Translate: volume + notes + next step. Map 'no' to ILT objections: time, price, 'not ready,' 'we already have a program.' Always leave a next event or scholarship deadline, not a dead lead.

Q: This is a small team. Are you OK wearing extra hats?

A: Yes — and I'll still protect the SDR job: pipeline, activity, clean CRM, handoff. I won't freelance curriculum. I'll ask what 'done' looks like each week so I don't become unpaid ops.

Q: What do you know about me / Kenzie?

A: You've been the operational backbone — applications through graduation, Batch Facilitator. Promoted Jul 2026 to Senior BD & Admissions Exec to build partnerships with EDOs, state agencies, sponsors. Prior: ILT associate, gener8tor associate, Raymond James financial advisor (LinkedIn). You care about builder experience AND expanding access. I would not come in trying to 'run sales over you.'

Q: How do you use AI in this job?

A: They sell AI-native entrepreneurship. Answer: research EDOs, draft first-touch in their voice, summarize partner 990s/annual reports, never fake personalization. Match Elijah Tietz's lane: AI as operations leverage, not spam cannon.

Q: Where do you want to be in 12 months?

A: Owning a clean partner or admissions funnel with predictable seat-fill. If the shop is 9 people, the path is AE/admissions closer or partnership coordinator — not 'VP of Sales' theater. Ask them what the path actually is.

7. 5 SMART QUESTIONS FOR KENZIE

1. Is this SDR seat primarily filling paid/scholarship **builder seats**, booking **partner conversations**, or a split — and what does a good week look like in numbers?
2. What's the current mix of inbound vs outbound, and do SDRs get a named territory (states/EDOs) or a shared admissions queue?
3. When a partner says they already fund SBDC / gBETA / LaunchMN, how do *you* describe ILT so it's a complement, not a fight?
4. Summer 2026 cohorts start in ~9 months. What's the real urgency this quarter — partner contracts, scholarship applications, or paid enrollment?
5. How do you measure success in the first 90 days, and what does training look like on a team this size — shadowing you in sessions, or a list and a phone?

Bonus if the conversation is good:

How is a sponsored cohort priced vs the \$3k/\$6k list — per seat, per cohort, grant-shaped? (Unknown publicly.) And: Northspan page says 7 Native Nations; About says 6 — I don't need the trivia, but it tells me you care about getting the region right.

8. RED FLAGS / VERIFY ON THE CALL

Do not be cynical. Be specific. Small mission-driven shops can be excellent or messy.

- **No public job post found.** Confirm: title, W-2 vs contract, hours, remote vs St. Cloud, who you report to (Kenzie vs Nick).
- **Comp:** base / variable / commission on tuition vs partner contracts vs seats filled. Clawbacks if a founder refunds or a grant slips. Draw vs ramp. Unknown until they say it.
- **Leads:** provided (webinar, application, partner inbound) vs self-sourced cold EDO list. If 100% self-source with no data room, that's a grind on a 9-person team.
- **Quota math:** 100 Series nights are 4 hours; cohorts are finite. If quota is 'unlimited SaaS meetings' but product is 2–3 cohorts a season, the number must match cohort capacity + partner pipeline.
- **Training:** Kenzie still batch-facilitates. Will you be pulled into classroom ops? That's learning the product — and a trap if it kills prospecting time.
- **Ramp:** Next live 100 Series is June 2026. What do you sell Sep–May? Scholarships, partners, waitlist, 300 Series, sprints/webinars? If they can't answer, the role is undefined.
- **Tools:** CRM unknown. Ask what they use and whether activity is tracked.
- **Founder-led sales:** Nick is "chief why guy" and leads every cohort personally (site). That's a product strength and a bottleneck. Ask who closes partners.
- **Entity:** Site copyright ILT Studios; product is ILT Academy. Confirm who writes the paycheck.

- **Culture tell:** #ilikethat, serious-builder energy, anti-fluff. Match it. Don't pitch 'crush quota / smash phones.'

IF THEY ASK 'ANY QUESTIONS FOR ME?' — PICK 3

1) Seat vs partner split + weekly numbers. 2) Inbound vs outbound + territory. 3) 90-day success + how training works. Then: comp/leads only after they like you — or if they open it. Close: "I can start fast. I already speak builder and partner. I want to make sure Summer 2026 is oversubscribed, not hoped-for."

PEOPLE / NUMBERS TO REMEMBER

- **Nick Tietz** — Founder & CEO, St. Cloud. Curriculum architect. "Chief why guy." Leads every cohort personally (site).
- **Kenzie Kitzman** — Interviewer. Site: Ops & Admissions Lead + Batch Facilitator. LinkedIn Jul 8, 2026: promoted to Senior BD and Admissions Executive. Email [kenzie@](mailto:kenzie@iltacademy.io) / [admissions@](mailto:admissions@iltacademy.io).
- **Also on About:** Adrian Grant (EIR) · Misha Lepetic (EIR) · Kristin Sullivan (Digital Commerce) · Elijah Tietz (AI Systems & Ops). LinkedIn also surfaces Mary MacCarthy, Lisa Kosciuk as mentors/EIRs.
- **Proof stats (use exactly):** 1,200+ founders · \$27M+ alumni capital · 55 cohorts · 850+ companies · \$572K SSBCI · Northspan: 139 entrepreneurs, 16 cohorts, 10 counties, 7 Native Nations (partners page).
- **Price:** \$3,000 / \$6,000. Team 15% off. Scholarships partner-funded, no cost except time.
- **Phones on site:** 320-322-8367 (footer) and 320-406-1490 (scholarships/partners). Emails: [hello@](mailto:hello@iltacademy.io) · [partner@](mailto:partner@iltacademy.io) · [admissions@](mailto:admissions@iltacademy.io) · [kenzie@](mailto:kenzie@iltacademy.io).
- **Dates:** 100 Series Jun 2/4 – Aug 13, 2026. Pitch Night Jun 23. Showcase Aug 13. 300 Series Jun 1 – Aug 11. Demo Day Aug 12 12:00–3:30 PM CST.

9. SOURCES (live web, Sep 2, 2026)

- <https://iltacademy.io> — homepage, proof stats, Summer 2026, partners logos, \$3,000, scholarships
- <https://iltacademy.io/about> — mission, founded 2020 St. Cloud, team, HQ, Northspan/ND, virtual
- <https://iltacademy.io/programs/100-series> — curriculum, \$3k/\$2,550, deliverables, Kenzie contact
- <https://iltacademy.io/programs/300-series> — \$6k, 100 required, Demo Day, vs accelerator FAQ
- <https://iltacademy.io/scholarships/100-series> — Northspan / GSCDC counties, 3-step admissions, 320-406-1490
- <https://iltacademy.io/partners> — "You fund the seats," \$572K SSBCI, partner quotes, partner types
- <https://iltacademy.io/partnership/> — older partner list: MN State, Launch MN, Red Wing Ignite, E1, GSCDC, Studio180
- <https://www.linkedin.com/company/ilt-academy-startup> — ~9 staff; Jul 2026 Kenzie promotion post
- https://www.linkedin.com/posts/ilt-academy-startup_ilikethat-activity-7480696281137393664-HEIj — promotion text
- <https://www.linkedin.com/in/kenzie-kitzman-08195b161/> — (fetch timed out; data from search index: CO Springs, gener8tor, Raymond James)
- <https://www.linkedin.com/in/nick-tietz> — Founder/CEO, Minneapolis listing on index vs HQ St. Cloud
- <https://www.dot.state.mn.us/shared-mobility/moving-forward-phase1.html> — MnDOT + ILT 10-week lean startup
- <https://blog.stcloudshines.com/blog/ilt-academy> — older local copy; EdTech / ecosystem framing
- <https://www.beta.mn/> — adjacent MN accelerator (not named by ILT)
- Meet: <https://meet.google.com/zxz-gtdb-gby>

Not verified: SDR offer details, commission, lead source mix, CRM, headcount beyond site/LinkedIn, Kenzie's current day-to-day split, whether this role is admissions or partnerships. If it's not on this sheet, say "I don't know — that's why I wanted to ask you."